> the sight in May 2004, after the world's then-largest democratic exercise, of a victorious leader of Roman Catholic background and Italian heritage, Sonia Gandhi, making way for a Sikh, Manmohan Singh, to be sworn in as Prime Minister by a Muslim, President Abdul Kalam, in a country 81 per cent Hindu, caught the world's imagination and won its admiration.[32]

Indeed, India's innate *religious* pluralism stands in contrast to China, where the practice of any faith is closely regulated or altogether prohibited by the state.[33] Among other initiatives, the Indian government is seeking to emphasise Buddhism and Sufism as particular Indian belief systems that reflect universal and inclusive philosophies.

In the case of Buddhism, there has been a palpable shift in India's "neigh-bourhood first" and "Act East" policies, with a push to underscore this faith to forge binding links. While leading Buddha Purnima prayers hosted by the International Buddhist Confederation in 2015, Prime Minister Modi declared "without Buddha, this cannot be Asia's century."[34] Modi embraced Buddhism as a major pillar of his strategy to rope in peripheral states in the neighbourhood. For example, in 2017 he travelled to Sri Lanka specifically as chief guest for the Vesak celebrations, the day that marks the birth, enlightenment, and passing away of Lord Buddha.[35] Through the Archaeological Survey of India, India has also stepped up support for renovation and conservation of Buddhist temples in Myanmar.[36]

In 2015, Modi had promised that "India would take the lead in boosting Buddhist heritage across Asia."[37] He then invited significant Buddhist representatives from Mongolia, Taiwan, Vietnam, Russia, Sri Lanka, Bhutan, and Mongolia to the Mahabodhi temple in Bodh Gaya to announce his vision of developing it as a spiritual hub to serve as a bond between India and the Buddhist world.[38] This built on efforts